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months of intense cricket, where conditions will vary, fitness and skills will be tested, and teams will strive to give their best.

As the game has evolved over the past decade, the Ranji Trophy has also witnessed the rise of newer teams, breaking the dominance of traditionally strong sides.

Since 2014, Karnataka has won the title just once, while Mumbai has added only two more trophies to its collection. In the same period, two less high-profile teams — Vidarbha and Saurashtra — have each claimed the title twice, with Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh winning in 2016 and 2022, respectively.

"The fact that a team like Mumbai, which is used to winning, had to wait nearly 10 years to claim a Ranji Trophy title (last season) speaks volumes about the competition," says Chandrakant Pandit.

Pandit, who was the head coach of Vidarbha when it secured back-to-back titles in 2018 and 2019, also guided Madhya Pradesh to its historic win against Mumbai in the final a couple of years ago.

"There is a lot of competition, and every team participating in the tournament wants to win. It's no longer just one or two teams dominating the show," says Pandit.

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"That dominance among top teams is no longer visible because of the widespread nature of the game. It's reached the nooks and corners of the country, and each State now has a lot of talent," says Jaydev Unadkat.

An India international, Unadkat has led Saurashtra to two Ranji Trophy titles in recent years. Having witnessed these changes firsthand, he has no hesitation in admitting that alongside the growing talent pool, the facilities across the country have significantly improved — even in remote areas.

"Earlier, there was a notion that only five or six major centres had state-of-the-art facilities, but that's no longer the case. Now, every state has a ground that is almost of international standard. Be it Vizianagaram in Andhra Pradesh or Jodhpur in Rajasthan — even though they don't regularly host games — these places have some of the best practice facilities in the country," Unadkat explains.

"These are some of the reasons why so many players are emerging from all parts of the country, and the fact that now at least 18 to 19 teams are capable of winning the Ranji Trophy shows how much the game has grown."

Bengal captain Anustup Majumdar echoes a similar sentiment. When Majumdar and Unadkat began their careers, the idea of separate teams for red-ball and white-ball cricket was almost unheard of. "A lot of teams now



have a different pool for red-ball and white-ball because of the amount of talent that we have," Majumdar says.

Unadkat agrees. "When we started, there were about 15 or 16 players who would play in every format. But now, even the associations have realised the need for separate teams. If you look at Saurashtra, we have quite a few different players for red-ball and